Apex Systems - Proposal

RFP NWH-AI-2026-01: Enterprise AI Platform & Implementation
Prepared for Northwind Holdings (fictional) | Submitted 5 October 2026

SYNTHETIC PROPOSAL - fictional supplier created for an academic exercise. Not real company data.

1. Executive Summary

Apex Systems proposes Apex Cortex, a single-tenant enterprise AI platform that gives Northwind employees grounded, permission-aware answers across SharePoint, Confluence, ServiceNow and the SAP S/4HANA document store. The platform is deployed inside Northwind's own Azure tenant so that no corporate content leaves the client's control.

We propose a 24-week, three-phase delivery with a 300-user pilot before enterprise rollout. Our design prioritises answer accuracy, security and long-term scalability over the fastest possible go-live.

2. Proposed Architecture

- Ingestion layer with incremental connectors, OCR for scanned documents and table-aware parsing.
- Hybrid retrieval: vector search combined with keyword (BM25) search and a cross-encoder re-ranker.
- LLM gateway supporting multiple model providers with policy-based routing and automatic fallback.
- Every answer includes citations to the source passages used.
- Evaluation harness with a 500-question golden set; go-live target of at least 90% grounded answers.
- Load-tested by Apex to 20 million documents and 5,000 concurrent users.

3. Integrations

Prebuilt connectors for SharePoint Online, Confluence Cloud, ServiceNow and SAP S/4HANA (OData). Single sign-on uses Microsoft Entra ID (SAML 2.0 / OIDC). Retrieval honours source-system permissions; access control lists are re-synchronised every 15 minutes. A REST API and a ServiceNow portal widget are included for ticket deflection.

4. Implementation Approach and Timeline

Phase	Weeks	Key outcomes
1. Discovery and foundation	1-6	Requirements, Azure landing zone, security design approved
2. Build and integrate	7-16	Four connectors live, golden-set evaluation above 85%
3. Pilot and rollout	17-24	300-user pilot, hardening, enterprise go-live

Dependency: Northwind must provide the Azure subscription and connector service accounts by week 3. Any delay moves the plan day for day.

5. Team Structure

An 11-person team: engagement lead, project manager, solution architect, security architect, two ML engineers, three data and integration engineers, a QA engineer and a part-time change management lead.

6. Pricing and Commercial Assumptions

Item	Amount (USD)

Platform subscription (up to 5,000 users), per year	420,000
Implementation services, fixed fee	385,000
Optional premium 24x7 support, per year	60,000
Three-year total (subscription + implementation)	1,645,000

Azure consumption is billed to Northwind directly (estimated USD 8,000-12,000 per month). Cleansing of legacy content is excluded. Prices are valid for 90 days.

7. Security and Compliance

- ISO/IEC 27001:2022 certified (certificate APX-27K-0412, fictional).
- SOC 2 Type II report for the 2025 audit period, available under NDA.
- AES-256 encryption at rest, TLS 1.3 in transit, customer-managed keys supported.
- Data residency in the Azure region selected by Northwind; no customer data is used to train models.
- Role-based access control; prompts and responses are audit-logged to Northwind's SIEM for 12 months.
- PII redaction before model calls; independent red-team testing before go-live; aligned to NIST AI RMF.

8. Risks and Mitigations

- Complex source permissions: permission mapping workshop in phase 1 and automated ACL tests.
- Azure quota approval delays: quota requests raised in week 1.
- Poor legacy content quality: content audit during discovery; cleansing can be quoted separately.

9. Support Arrangements

Standard support is business hours (9x5). P1 incidents are handled 24x7 with a one-hour response target; P2 incidents within four business hours. Quarterly model performance reviews are included. Full 24x7 coverage for all priorities requires the optional premium support package.

10. Experience and References

Founded in 2014, Apex has delivered 38 enterprise AI deployments. References: Meridian Federal Bank (8,000 users, enterprise search) and Halcyon Energy (field knowledge assistant). Both references are fictional for this exercise.